CWMG regarding the meeting with the viceroy on 19 March 1931. But Utpal Aich has argued that 'since the versions of the Viceroy are in English and duly validated by his initials at the end of the texts, these appear to be more authentic . . .'.[6]

Utpal Aich may well not be wrong because less than two weeks earlier, on 7 March 1931, Gandhi addressed a public meeting in New Delhi.[7] What he said here makes it abundantly clear that he had already given up on Bhagat Singh because he did not agree with his ways: 'If you pin your faith to violence, take it from me that you will not only not secure Bhagat Singh's release but will have to sacrifice thousands of Bhagat Singhs. I was not prepared to do so, and hence I preferred the way of peace, of non-violence.'[8] On 19 March, Gandhi had an interview with the viceroy on his return from Bombay on the matter of India's financial credit and stability. We learn that he says of the viceroy that '[h]is general attitude was friendly' and that at the end of the meeting '[a]s he was leaving, he asked if he might mention the case of Bhagat Singh, saying that he had seen in the Press the intimation of his execution for March 24th'. His concern, however, was that '[t]his was an unfortunate day, as it coincided with the arrival of the new President of the Congress at Karachi and there would be much popular excitement'. The viceroy assured him, saying,

> I told him I had considered the case with most anxious care, but could find no grounds on which I could justify to my conscience commuting the sentence. As to the date, I had considered the possibility of postponement till after the Congress, but had deliberately rejected it on various grounds . . . He appeared to appreciate the force of these arguments, and said no more.[9]

And two days before Bhagat Singh was hanged, Gandhi in his interview to the press on 21 March 1931, when asked, 'Do you entertain any hope that Bhagat Singh may be saved at the last minute?', answered that 'Yes, but it is a very distant hope'.[10]

Second, we have the damning statement of Dr Pattabhi Sitaramayya. A gifted polymath, he was the official historian of the Congress Party. He was also Gandhi's protégé and was nominated by him as president of Congress